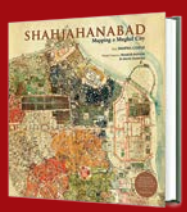
PAST PERFECT

A rare glimpse into **Old Delhi** before the post-1857 demolitions changed it forever

Everyone has heard of 'Paranthe Wali Gali' in Old Delhi. However, few would know of 'Samoson ki Gali', which, along with many other such place names from the 19th century, has not survived. Trivia apart, this book is a meticulously researched account of Mughal Delhi before 1857. The British were determined to teach a lesson after the Revolt and demolished great swathes of the city. This has made the reconstruction of late Mughal Delhi a challenge for historians, and one important source is a large-scale, thana-by-thana, coloured map from 1846-47, which the book reproduces in detail. The work of a colonial official or a team, the map certainly had indigenous collaborators as place names were written in Urdu. The map records areas that have long disappeared, including a plan of the regal quarters in Red Fort that were destroyed by the British.



SHAHJAHANABAD
Mapping a Mughal City
By Swapna Liddle
ROLI BOOKS
₹2,495; 108 pages

Swapna Liddle has collated information from contemporary sources, and her commentary on localities, landlords, religious structures and commercial establishments is a joy to read. Pre-1857 Delhi presented a complex picture. British rule had introduced civic administration and modern education, and there was change in the air. Historian Narayani Gupta has pointed out that defence and security prompted the British in the early 1800s to replace the mud wall with a modern European-style wall with bastions, which strengthened the enclosed character of Delhi.

The map shows the ecology of a traditional South Asian city characterised by mixed land use, where the rich lived, according to Liddle, 'cheek by jowl' with the working classes. The built form comprised *mohallas* (neighbourhoods), *havelis* and *kothis* (mansions), *katras* (commercial spaces), *ahatas* (enclosures), *chhattas* (arcades), *khidkis* (wicket gates), gardens, mosques, madrasas and workshops.

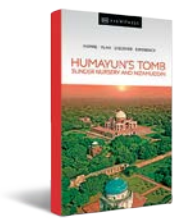
Delhi was not an Islamic city though—less than 50 per cent of its population was Muslim. The dense settlements with narrow, shaded lanes and cul de sacs, dynamic use of courtyards and rooftops are a lesson for conservators today, struggling to economise spaces and deal with climate change.

The nature of Mughal Delhi kept changing, not least because of political turmoil, reflected in the turnover of estates and new claimants to status. The nawabs of Awadh owned extensive property, which marked the presence of Shias. The Marathas contributed many *wadas* (Maliwara, Jogiwara). Syed Ahmed Khan was not in Delhi when the rebels captured it; his neighbour Mufti Ikramuddin signed the rebel declaration. Rebels were hanged and their properties were given to loyalists. All this and much more is available in this book, and one can spend hours poring over the map—which also comes as a separate pull-out. Pramod Kapoor, Sneha Pamneja and their team at Roli Books have done a wonderful job of designing and production, making this book a collector's item. ■

Partho Datta

Garden of Earthly Delights

This is a visually rich heritage and habitat guide to ***Humayun's Tomb*** *and adjacent areas*



HUMAYUN'S TOMB, SUNDER NURSERY AND NIZAMUDDIN
Edited by Anuroop Sanwalia and Chhavi Nagpal
DORLING KINDERSLEY
₹799; 224 pages

Set in a charbagh-style Mughal garden, Humayun's Tomb is arguably Delhi's greatest architectural gem. Over the last decade and a half, this World Heritage Site and its adjacent areas and monuments have been nursed back to their former glory by the Aga Khan Trust for Culture (AKTC) under the uncompromising stewardship of conservation architect Ratish Nanda.

In 2007, AKTC signed an MoU to undertake the Nizamuddin Urban Renewal Initiative that has included the conservation of Humayun's Tomb, the creation of Sunder Nursery and development works in Nizamuddin Basti. Before that, in 1997, AKTC had undertaken the restoration of the Humayun's Tomb garden as a gift of the Aga Khan to mark the 50th anniversary of Indian independence. Spread across 90 acres and housing 20 monuments (six of them part of the Humayun's Tomb UNESCO citation), including 16th-century wells, Sunder Nursery opened in 2018 and has been dubbed Delhi's own Central Park. The Humayun's Tomb Museum will open later this year.

It's one of the great restoration dramas of our time. Now, a guidebook in the visual-heavy DK Eyewitness mould takes note of these monumental improvements in a user-friendly format. The guide is split into three parts—Humayun's Tomb Complex, Sunder Nursery and Nizamuddin—and encompasses around 60 monuments. The illustrations of the monuments, including some cross sections, are to be savoured.

Handy six-hour and



12-hour itineraries have been provided, as well as walking routes through Sunder Nursery and Nizamuddin Basti, a guide for foodies, and ample doses of historical and cultural context.

It also showcases the habitats that house the monuments, with detailed guides to the flora and fauna of the area. This is the guide's crowning glory—tying the silent monuments to the living world around them. ■

Amit Dixit